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History

Colonialism and Rural Society: Evidence from Official Reports

Themes in Indian History Part III · Chapter 10 · Colonialism and the Countryside (c. 1770–1878 CE)

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Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

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Official Syllabus Breakdown & Exam Scope

Derived from **Themes in Indian History Part III** (Chapter 10: "Colonialism and the Countryside: Exploring Official Archives"), this unit examines how British colonial rule transformed rural property relations, fiscal extraction, peasant credit, and tribal ecologies across eastern and western India during the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries.

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer & key NCERT anchors	Skills the questions test
1. Bengal & Permanent Settlement	Auction in Burdwan (1797); Lord Cornwallis (1793); Sunset Law; high revenue demand; rise of Jotedars (**haoladars**, **gantidars**); sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**); **benami** transactions and zamindari resistance.	Institutional mechanics, legal terminology, socioeconomic dynamics of agrarian power.
2. The Fifth Report & Archives	Fifth Report (1813); British Parliamentary Select Committee; critiques of East India Company monopoly; official petitions; historiographical bias and exaggeration of zamindari ruin.	Historiographical criticism, evaluation of colonial archives, primary source analysis.
3. The Hoe & The Plough	Francis Buchanan's surveys; **Paharias** of Rajmahal hills (shifting cultivation, forest gathering, **kural** / hoe); Augustus Cleveland's pacification; **Santhals** (settled plough agriculture); **Damin-i-Koh** (1832).	Ecological history, symbolic analysis of tools, frontier expansion policies.
4. The Santhal Hul (1855–56)	Moneylenders (**dikus**); extortionate interest rates; zamindari land alienation; leadership of Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu; rebellion trajectory; creation of **Santhal Pargana** (1855).	Rebellion timelines, subaltern leadership, colonial administrative reorganizations.
5. Bombay Deccan & Deccan Riots	Ryotwari settlement; Ricardian rent theory; American Civil War & Cotton Boom (1861–65); Limitation Law of 1859; uprising at Supa (Poona, May 1875); burning of **bahikhatas**; Deccan Riots Commission (1878).	Macro-economic linkages, legal-financial mechanisms, peasant protest typology.

HIGH-YIELD NTA CUET DISTINCTION: THE HOE VS THE PLOUGH

In NCERT, the conflict in the Rajmahal hills is framed as the epic battle between the **Hoe** and the **Plough**:

The Hoe (Paharia Shifting Cultivators & Forest Hunters) ↔ **The Plough** (Santhal Settled Agriculturists Backed by the Colonial State)

The British viewed shifting agriculture with the hoe as primitive, undisciplined, and untaxable. They actively invited Santhals to clear the forests with the plough to establish taxable, sedentary agricultural revenue villages within **Damin-i-Koh**.

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Sub-Topic 1: Bengal and the Zamindars: The Permanent Settlement

1.1 An Auction in Burdwan (1797)

In **1797**, an extensive public auction was held at Burdwan (present-day Bardhaman in West Bengal). Numerous **mahals** (revenue estates) belonging to the Raja of Burdwan were being auctioned off by the British East India Company to recover unpaid revenue arrears.

However, British collectors soon discovered a bizarre outcome:

- Almost all the highest bidders at the auction were servants and confidential agents of the Raja himself.
- Over 95% of the sales were entirely **fictitious** (**benami**). The Raja's agents outbid outside purchasers, intentionally defaulted on paying the purchase price, forced the Company to re-auction the land, and eventually bought back the estates at a fraction of their original assessed valuation.

1.2 The Permanent Settlement of 1793

The **Permanent Settlement** was introduced in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa in **1793** under the governor-generalship of **Lord Charles Cornwallis**:

- **Property Conversion**: Traditional regional **rajas** and **taluqdars** were legally recognized as **Zamindars** (proprietors of the soil).
- **Invariable Revenue**: The revenue demand payable to the Company was **fixed in perpetuity**. The British assumed that a fixed demand would encourage zamindars to invest capital in improving agricultural productivity, draining swamps, and expanding cultivation, secure in the knowledge that the state would not claim increased taxes.
- **The Sunset Law**: The administration enforced uncompromising payment discipline. Under the **Sunset Law**, if the stipulated revenue installment was not deposited in the Company's treasury by sunset of the specified date, the zamindar's estate was immediately liable to be confiscated and auctioned to the highest bidder.

1.3 Why Zamindars Defaulted on Revenue Payments

During the initial decades following 1793, over 75% of zamindari estates were auctioned. The causes of widespread defaults included:

1. **Excessive Initial Assessment**: Expecting future agricultural expansion that they could never tax, the British deliberately set the initial revenue assessment artificially high.

2. **Agricultural Depression of the 1790s**: High revenue was imposed during a period of depressed grain prices. Cultivators could not sell their crops at prices high enough to pay their dues to the zamindar.
3. **Inelastic State Demand**: The revenue was invariant regardless of monsoon failure, floods, or crop devastation.
4. **Curtailed Judicial & Police Powers**: The Company severely restricted the traditional coercive authority of zamindars:
   - Zamindars' private armed retainers were disbanded.
   - Local customs duties were abolished.
   - Their **kacharis** (revenue courts) were placed under the supervision of a British Collector.
   - The local police (**thanas**) were placed under the control of government-appointed **darogas**, stripping zamindars of the power to coerce defaulting peasants.

1.4 The Rise of the Jotedars

While traditional zamindars struggled, a class of rich peasants known as **Jotedars** consolidated power in the villages of North Bengal (especially Dinajpur, Rangpur, and Jalpaiguri):

- **Regional Nomenclature**: Jotedars were also referred to as **haoladars**, **gantidars**, or **mandals**.
- **Economic Base**: They controlled thousands of acres of land, dominated local village moneylending, and engaged in grain trade.
- **Sharecropping System**: Jotedars did not cultivate land directly; they rented out their land to sharecroppers known as **adhiyars** or **bargadars**, who brought their own plows, provided labor, and surrendered half the harvested crop (**half-share**) to the jotedar.
- **Subverting the Zamindar**: Unlike absentee zamindars who lived in grand urban mansions in Calcutta, jotedars resided directly within the villages. They actively incited poor peasants to delay paying rents to the zamindar, resisted zamindari revenue collectors (**amlah**), and bought up auctioned zamindari estates when the zamindar defaulted.

1.5 Strategies of Zamindari Survival

Confronted with the Sunset Law and auctions, zamindars developed sophisticated survival strategies:

- **Benami Transfers**: The Raja of Burdwan transferred substantial portions of his zamindari to his mother, knowing that the Company's law strictly prohibited the attachment or auction of women's personal property.
- **Auction Manipulation**: When an estate was put up for auction, the zamindar's agents bid astronomical amounts to drive away genuine outside purchasers. The agents then refused to deposit the purchase money. The estate had to be re-auctioned repeatedly, driving the price down until the zamindar repurchased his own land through nominees.
- **Physical Intimidation**: If an outsider managed to purchase an estate, the zamindar's retainers (**lathyals**, club-wielding men) physically attacked the new purchaser's agents and evicted them. Village peasants, loyal to their traditional raja, refused to acknowledge outside purchasers. Between 1793 and 1801, four of the largest zamindaris in Bengal, including Burdwan, engineered fictitious sales to survive intact.

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Sub-Topic 2: The Fifth Report and the Historiographical Archive

2.1 Context and Purpose of the Fifth Report

The **Fifth Report** was the fifth in a series of administrative reports submitted to the British Parliament in **1813** by a Select Committee appointed to inquire into the governance and commerce of the East India Company:

- **Monopoly Challenge**: In Britain, private merchants, industrialists, and political figures agitated against the East India Company's royal monopoly over trade with India and China. They sought access to Indian markets and seized upon instances of Company misgovernance.
- **Documentary Composition**: The report ran into **1,002 folio pages**, of which over **800 pages** consisted of statistical appendices, copies of collectors' official letters, judicial court minutes, and petitions of distressed zamindars.

2.2 Critical Evaluation of the Fifth Report

For over a century, historians accepted the **Fifth Report** at face value as conclusive proof of the universal collapse of traditional Bengal landed society under the Permanent Settlement. Modern historical scholarship, however, offers a nuanced critique:

- **Political Bias**: The Select Committee was politically motivated to paint a bleak portrait of Company misrule to justify the British Parliament revoking the Company's trade monopoly (enacted through the **Charter Act of 1813**).
- **Exaggerated Ruin**: The report exaggerated the extent of zamindari collapse. While many small estates were indeed broken up, the great zamindaris survived through **benami** transactions and legal chicanery.

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Sub-Topic 3: Comparative Analysis: Permanent Settlement vs Ryotwari

To grasp how colonial land settlements transformed different regions of India, the comparative architecture below juxtaposes Bengal's Permanent Settlement with the Bombay Deccan's Ryotwari system:

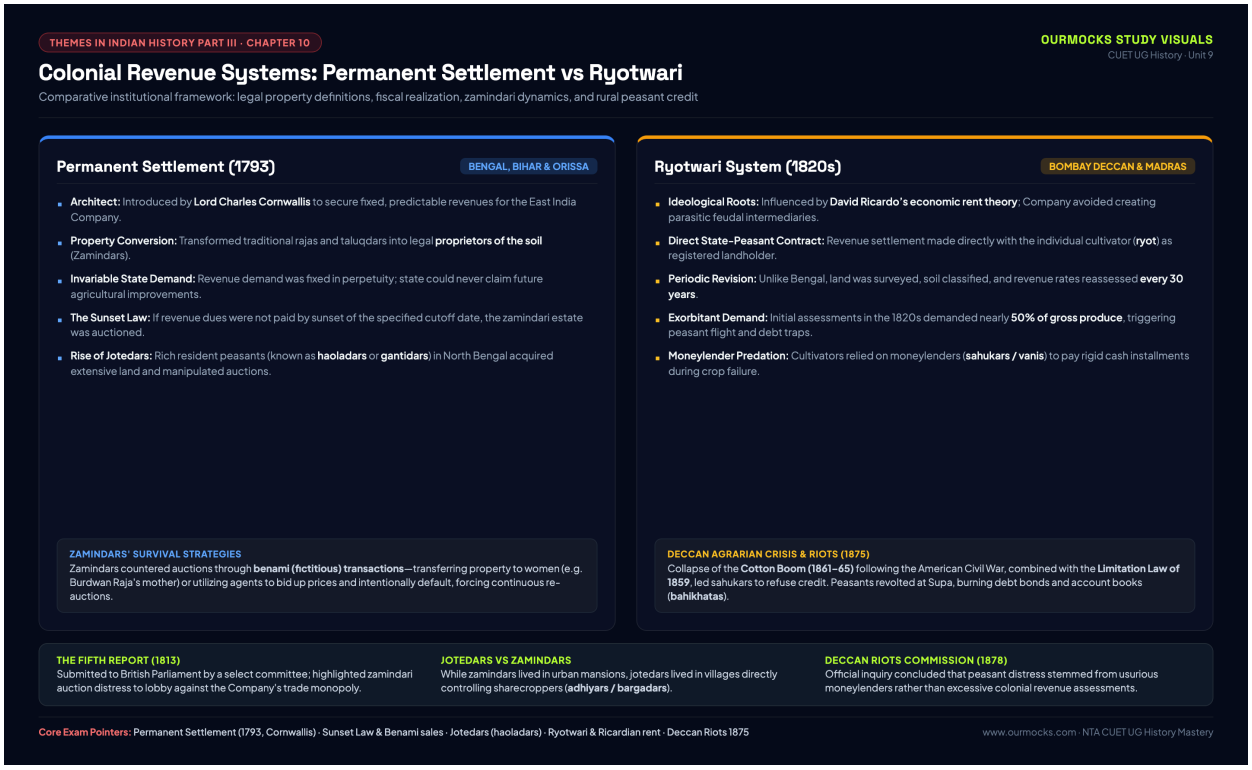


Figure 1: Comparative Framework of Colonial Land Revenue Systems: Permanent Settlement vs Ryotwari

3.1 Structural Contrast

1. **Legal Landlord**: In Bengal, the zamindar was the legal proprietor of the soil; in the Deccan, the individual peasant (**ryot**) was the registered occupant.
2. **Demand Permanence**: Bengal's demand was fixed in perpetuity; Deccan assessments were subject to upward revision every 30 years.
3. **Agrarian Intermediary**: Bengal preserved the zamindar and produced the rich **jotedar**; the Deccan bypassed landlords, creating a direct dependency between the peasant and the usurious village moneylender (**sahukar**).

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Sub-Topic 4: The Hoe and the Plough: The Hills of Rajmahal

4.1 Francis Buchanan and Colonial Cartography

Francis Buchanan (later known as Buchanan-Hamilton) was a Scottish surgeon and employee of the East India Company who conducted extensive topographic, botanical, and statistical surveys of Bengal, Bihar, and Mysore between **1800 and 1815**:

- **The Colonial Lens**: Buchanan was not an impartial traveler; he traveled under government orders with a retinue of surveyors, draftsmen, palanquin bearers, and armed guards.
- **Commercial Gaze**: Buchanan surveyed landscapes with an eye for commercial exploitation. Wherever he observed uncultivated forests or rocky scrubland, he saw "wasted resources" that required clearing, timber extraction, and conversion into iron mines or taxable agricultural fields.

4.2 The Paharias: People of the Hoe

In the late eighteenth century, the hills around **Rajmahal** (in modern Jharkhand) were inhabited by the **Paharias**:

- **Livelihood**: The Paharias lived around hills and forests. They practiced **shifting cultivation** (**jhum**): clearing small jungle patches by burning undergrowth, scratching the soil with a small hand-hoe (**kural**), and planting coarse millets, pulses, and barley.
- **Forest Produce**: They gathered wild **mahua** flowers for brewing liquor, collected **silk cocoons** (tasar) and resin, and maintained charcoal kilns.
- **Social Structure**: Society was organized around chiefs who settled disputes, commanded warrior bands, and maintained ritual tribal unity.
- **Plains Raids**: During seasons of famine or drought, Paharia warrior bands raided settled agrarian villages in the plains, exacting tribute from zamindars in exchange for guaranteeing safety to passing merchant caravans.

4.3 British Pacification and Augustus Cleveland

In the 1770s, the British launched brutal military campaigns to exterminate the Paharias. However, in the **1780s**, **Augustus Cleveland**, the British Collector of Bhagalpur, instituted a **policy of pacification**:

- Paharia chiefs were granted monthly government allowances in cash.
- In return, chiefs were expected to maintain order, discipline their tribesmen, and surrender offenders to colonial magistrates.
- Many chiefs refused allowances, viewing them as bribes that undermined tribal independence. Those who accepted allowances lost authority among their people, being branded as paid puppets of the Company (**chaprasis**).
- As pacification faltered, the Paharias retreated deeper into the inaccessible crags of the Rajmahal hills, waging guerrilla warfare against encroaching plains cultivators.

4.4 The Santhals: Pioneers of the Plough

Starting in the late 1780s, the British turned to the **Santhals**, a settled agricultural community hailing from the Chotanagpur plateau, to clear the Rajmahal forests:

- **Colonization Frontier**: The British failed to induce the nomadic Paharias to abandon the hoe for the plough. Santhals, by contrast, were experienced forest clearers who readily felled sal timber, plowed fertile lowland soils, and practiced intensive settled agriculture.
- **Demarcation of Damin-i-Koh (1832)**: In **1832**, the colonial administration demarcated a large enclosed tract in the foothills of Rajmahal known as **Damin-i-Koh** ("skirts of the hills"):
  - Its perimeter was marked by massive masonry boundary pillars separating Santhal agricultural land from the hilly domain of the Paharias.
  - Within Damin-i-Koh, Santhals were granted land leases on the condition that they clear at least one-tenth of their holding within the first ten years.
  - The transformation was breathtaking: while there were only **40 Santhal villages** with a population of 3,000 in 1838, by **1851** there were **1,473 villages** with over **82,000 Santhals** cultivating the fertile valleys.

- **Displacement of Paharias**: As the Santhal agricultural frontier expanded, the Paharias were driven onto higher, barren granite crags. Denied access to lowland forests and pasturelands, the Paharia economy suffered crippling impoverishment.

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Sub-Topic 5: The Santhal Hul (Rebellion) of 1855–1856

5.1 Causes of the Rebellion

By the early 1850s, the Santhals realized that the land they had carved out of the wilderness was slipping from their grasp:

- **Diku Exploitation**: Outside moneylenders and merchants (**dikus**) infiltrated Damin-i-Koh, charging usurious interest rates (ranging from **50% to over 500%**). Illiterate Santhals were cheated with falsified accounts, forced into bonded labor (**kamioti**), and had their cattle and land seized upon default.
- **Colonial Revenue Exactions**: The Company administration sharply increased cash land revenue assessments on Santhal villages.
- **Zamindari Encroachments**: Plains zamindars asserted legal claims over forested fringes of Damin-i-Koh, supported by corrupt colonial police (**darogas**).

5.2 The Outbreak and Leadership

In **June 1855**, the Santhals rose in a massive armed rebellion, known in tribal history as the **Santhal Hul**:

- **Messianic Leadership**: The rebellion was led by two brothers, **Sidhu** and **Kanhu Murmu**, from the village of Bhagnadih. They claimed divine visions from the supreme deity, **Thakurji**, who commanded them to slaughter oppressive moneylenders, drive out the British, and establish an independent Santhal realm (**Santhal Raj**).
- **Military Uprising**: Armed with bows, poisoned arrows, battle-axes, and spears, thousands of Santhals attacked zamindari **kacharis**, torched moneylenders' homes, and executed corrupt police officials.

5.3 Suppression and Administrative Outcome

- **Colonial Repression**: The British responded with overwhelming military force. Martial law was declared; infantry regiments and elephant brigades swept through the hills, systematically burning Santhal settlements. Over 15,000 Santhals were killed, and both Sidhu and Kanhu were captured and executed.
- **Creation of Santhal Pargana (1855)**: Recognizing that unmediated exploitation threatened imperial security, the British passed the **Santhal Parganas Act of 1855**, carving out a separate administrative district of **5,500 square miles** called **Santhal Pargana** from the districts of Bhagalpur and Birbhum. Special tenancy regulations were enacted to protect tribal land from transfer to non-tribal **dikus**.

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Sub-Topic 6: The Bombay Deccan: Ryotwari System, Cotton Boom & The Deccan Riots

6.1 The Ryotwari Framework in Western India

In the Bombay Deccan, conquered from the Peshwas in 1818, the British implemented the **Ryotwari system**:

- **Ricardian Principles**: British officials (influenced by economist **David Ricardo**) believed that traditional landlords pocketed agricultural surplus without investing in improvements. Under Ryotwari, the state entered into a direct revenue agreement with the actual cultivator (**ryot**).
- **Oppressive Initial Rates**: The revenue demand was fixed at extraordinary levels—often claiming over **50% of the gross agricultural produce**. Cultivators faced immediate destitution during crop failures, leading to large-scale peasant abandonment of villages in the 1820s and 1830s.

6.2 The American Civil War and the Cotton Boom (1861–1865)

- **Raw Cotton Crisis**: Before 1861, Britain imported three-fourths of its raw cotton from the United States. When the **American Civil War** broke out in **1861**, the Union naval blockade severed American cotton shipments to the textile factories of Lancashire.
- **Turn to the Deccan**: The British Cotton Supply Association turned desperately to India. Indian merchants and European export houses dispatched millions of rupees in cash advances into the Bombay Deccan to stimulate cotton cultivation.
- **The Boom**: For four years (1861–1865), credit flowed effortlessly into the countryside. Moneylenders (**sahukars**) actively encouraged ryots to borrow large sums, financing deep digging, bullock purchases, and cotton sowing. Cotton acreage in the Deccan exploded.

6.3 Post-War Crash and the Limitation Law of 1859

- **The Slump (1865)**: In 1865, the American Civil War ended, and American cotton flooded British markets once again. Cotton prices in Bombay collapsed catastrophically.
- **Credit Freeze**: Local sahukars abruptly ceased advancing credit and demanded immediate repayment of existing loans.
- **The Limitation Law of 1859**: The colonial state had enacted the **Limitation Law** in **1859**, stating that loan bonds executed between moneylenders and borrowers were legally valid for only **three years**:
  - Designed to prevent the indefinite accumulation of compound interest, the law produced the exact opposite effect.
  - To prevent debts from expiring, sahukars forced illiterate ryots to sign entirely new bonds every three years, adding all unpaid accumulated interest directly into the new principal debt.
  - Sahukars refused to issue receipts for grain payments, entered fictitious loan sums, and forced ryots to sign blank papers (**kora kaghaz**).

6.4 The Deccan Riots of May 1875

Pushed to the brink of total dispossession, the peasantry of the Bombay Deccan erupted in rebellion in **May 1875**:

- **Epicenter**: The revolt commenced in the large market village of **Supa** in the Poona district.
- **Course of the Riots**:
  - Ryots instituted a social boycott against moneylenders, refusing to cultivate their fields, serve as domestic helpers, or sell them provisions.
  - When boycotts failed, crowds of peasants attacked the shops and mansions of the **sahukars**.
  - Significantly, the uprising was characterized by targeted symbolic violence: peasants demanded the surrender of debt bonds, promissory notes, and account books (**bahikhatas**). They burned these documents in public bonfires in the village square.
  - Physical violence against persons was rare; the sole objective was the destruction of the legal debt instruments that enslaved them.
- **Spread**: Over a few weeks, the riots swept through over 30 villages in Poona and Ahmadnagar districts before British military detachments restored order.

6.5 The Deccan Riots Commission (1878)

Alarmed by parallels with the 1857 rebellion, the Government of Bombay instituted a formal Commission of Inquiry:

- The **Deccan Riots Commission** visited affected districts, recorded statements of ryots, sahukars, and district magistrates, and collected statistical data on land auctions and debts.
- **Report to Parliament (1878)**: The Commission submitted a massive report to the British Parliament in **1878**.
- **Official Bias**: Predictably, the colonial report absolved the British revenue administration of all blame, asserting that the exorbitant colonial revenue demand was not the cause of rural distress. Instead, the report attributed peasant bankruptcy entirely to the deceitful usury of moneylenders and the peasant's alleged "reckless expenditure" on marriages and festivals.
- **Legislative Concession**: To mitigate rural unrest, the government passed the **Deccan Agriculturists' Relief Act of 1879**, ensuring that peasants could not be arrested or imprisoned for debt default.

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Sub-Topic 7: Chronological Trajectory of Rural Resistance

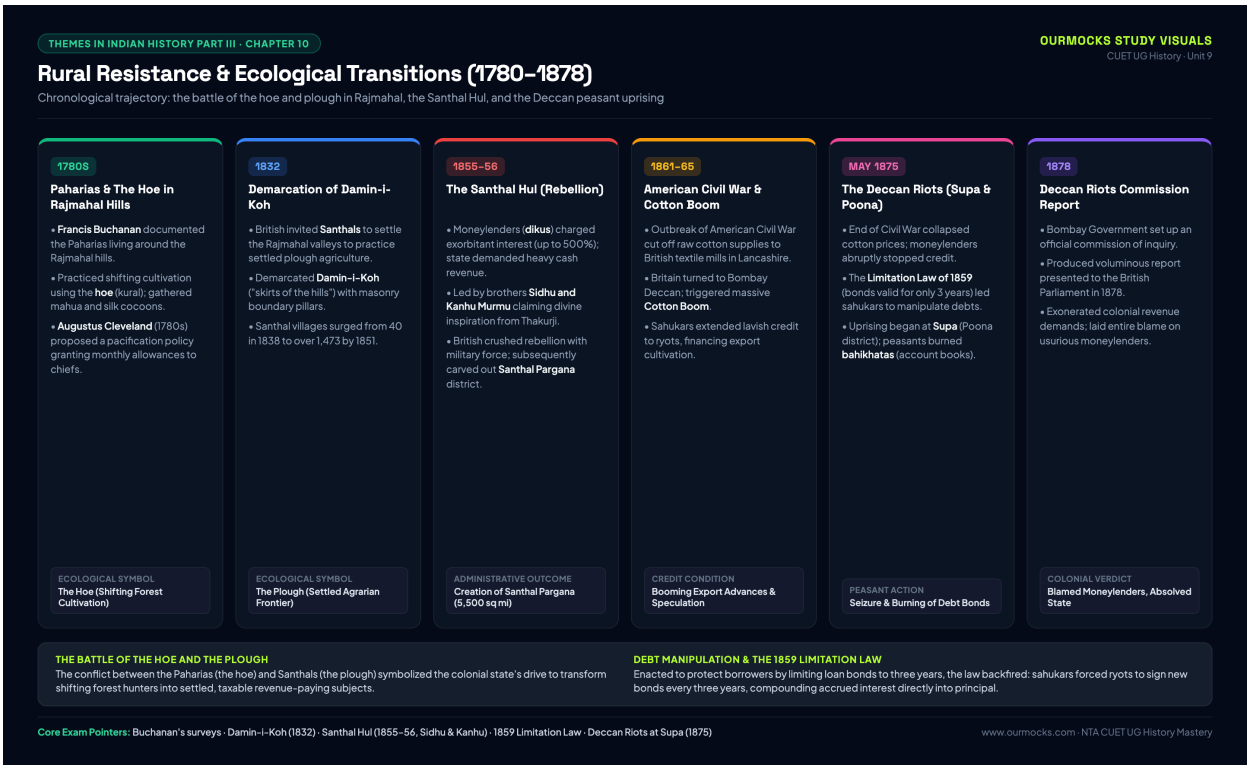


Figure 2: Chronological Trajectory of Rural Resistance and Agrarian Crisis (1780–1878)

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Sub-Topic 8: Comprehensive Chapter Synthesizer Mindmap

To synthesize all six analytical nodes of Chapter 10—Permanent Settlement, Jotedar dynamics, Fifth Report archives, the battle of the hoe and plough, the Santhal Hul, and the Deccan peasant uprising—the structural master mindmap below integrates the complete syllabus framework:

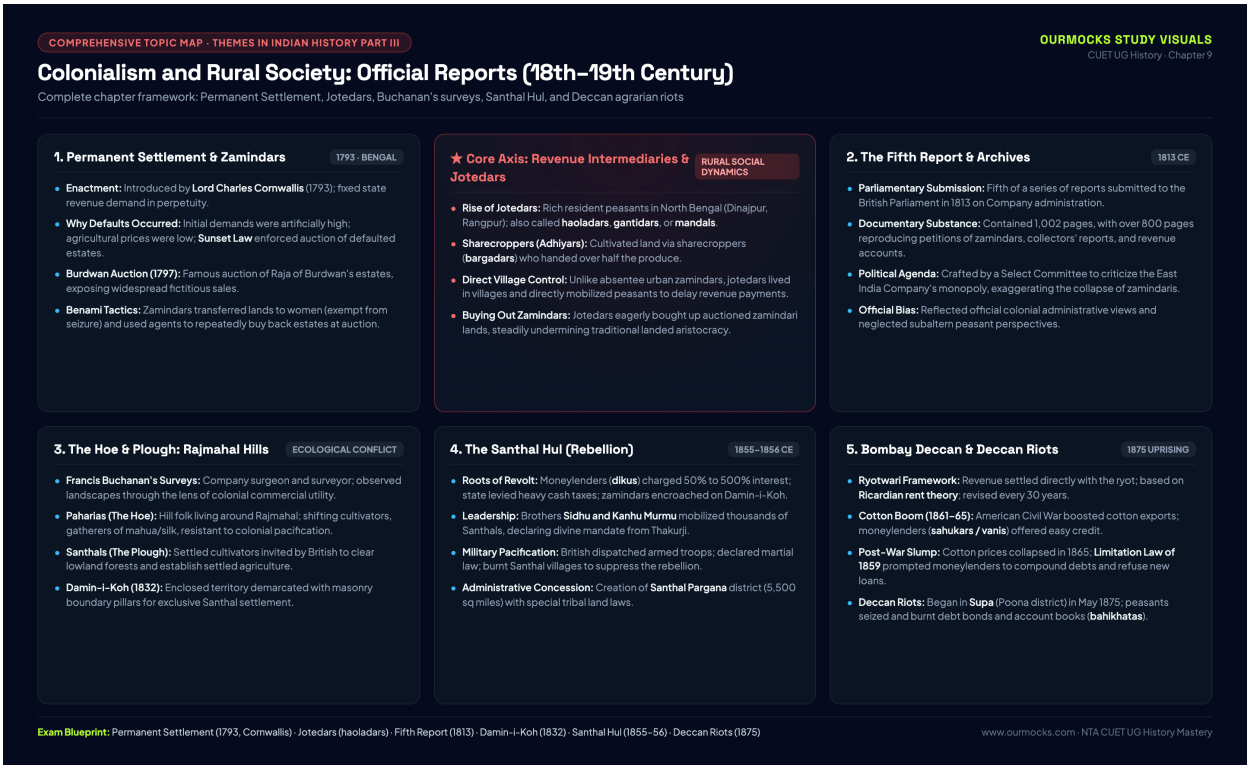


Figure 3: Comprehensive Synthesizer Mindmap: Colonialism and Rural Society

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High-Yield Chronology & Nomenclature Reference

Year / Period	Historical Milestone & Legislative Measure
1793 CE	Lord Cornwallis introduces the Permanent Settlement in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.
1797 CE	Fictitious auction of the Raja of Burdwan's estates; exposes **benami** survival strategies.
1800–1815 CE	Francis Buchanan conducts topographic and statistical surveys across Bengal, Bihar, and Rajmahal.
1813 CE	Submission of the **Fifth Report** on East India Company administration to the British Parliament.
1820s CE	Implementation of the **Ryotwari** land revenue system in the Bombay Deccan and Madras.
1832 CE	Demarcation of **Damin-i-Koh** in the Rajmahal foothills for exclusive Santhal settlement.
1855–1856 CE	The **Santhal Hul** (Rebellion) led by Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu; creation of **Santhal Pargana** district.
1859 CE	Enactment of the **Limitation Law** limiting the legal validity of loan bonds to three years.

Year / Period	Historical Milestone & Legislative Measure
1861–1865 CE	American Civil War; British textile mills turn to India, triggering the **Cotton Boom** in Bombay Deccan.
1875 CE (May)	Outbreak of the **Deccan Riots** at Supa (Poona district); public burning of **bahikhatas**.
1878 CE	Submission of the **Deccan Riots Commission Report** to the British Parliament.
1879 CE	Enactment of the **Deccan Agriculturists' Relief Act** protecting peasants from debt imprisonment.

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High-Yield NTA CUET Practice Questions (15 MCQs)

Q1. The Permanent Settlement was introduced in Bengal in 1793 under which Governor-General?

(A) Lord Warren Hastings
(B) Lord Charles Cornwallis
(C) Lord Wellesley
(D) Lord William Bentinck

Sol. Q1. The Permanent Settlement was enacted in 1793 by Lord Charles Cornwallis, fixing state land revenue demand in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa in perpetuity.

Answer: (B)

Q2. Under the colonial **Sunset Law**, what was the consequence if a zamindar failed to pay his revenue installment by sunset of the specified date?

(A) The zamindar was imprisoned for life
(B) His estate was immediately auctioned off by the Company
(C) His land was gifted to the local Jotedar
(D) The zamindar was demoted to a share-cropper

Sol. Q2. The Sunset Law stipulated that if the revenue was not paid into the treasury by sunset of the appointed day, the zamindar's estate was liable to be auctioned to the highest bidder.

Answer: (B)

Q3. Rich resident peasants in North Bengal who controlled vast tracts of land and dominated local moneylending were called:

(A) Bargadars
(B) Adhiyars
(C) Jotedars
(D) Lathyals

Sol. Q3. Rich resident peasants in North Bengal were known as **Jotedars** (also called **haoladars**, **gantidars**, or **mandals**). They cultivated land via sharecroppers (**adhiyars** / **bargadars**).

Answer: (C)

Q4. In the colonial official archives, the **Fifth Report** submitted to the British Parliament in 1813 was primarily designed to:

(A) Praise the East India Company's administrative brilliance
(B) Critique Company misgovernance and lobby against its commercial monopoly
(C) Advocate the abolition of the Ryotwari system in the Deccan
(D) Promote Santhal conversion to Christianity

Sol. Q4. The Fifth Report was drafted by a Parliamentary Select Committee to highlight Company misrule and financial disorder, providing political justification to revoke the Company's trade monopoly via the Charter Act of 1813.

Answer: (B)

Q5. Which agricultural implement was used by NCERT as a historical metaphor to represent the settled agrarian frontier promoted by the British in the Rajmahal hills?

(A) The Hoe
(B) The Sickle
(C) The Plough
(D) The Persian Wheel

Sol. Q5. The **Plough** symbolized the settled agriculture of the Santhals backed by the colonial state, while the **Hoe** symbolized the shifting subsistence cultivation of the Paharias.

Answer: (C)

Q6. The British designated a large enclosed tract in the Rajmahal foothills for Santhal settlement in 1832 known as:

(A) Damin-i-Koh
(B) Chotanagpur
(C) Santhal Pargana
(D) Kolhan

Sol. Q6. Damin-i-Koh ("skirts of the hills") was demarcated in 1832 with boundary pillars to settle Santhals as sedentary plough agriculturists.

Answer: (A)

Q7. The Santhal Rebellion (1855–1856) was led by which two brothers who claimed divine sanction from Thakurji?

(A) Birsa and Komal Munda
(B) Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu
(C) Tilka and Jitu Majhi
(D) Alluri and Rama Raju

Sol. Q7. The Santhal Hul was led by brothers **Sidhu** and **Kanhu Murmu** of Bhagnadih, who mobilized thousands of Santhals against moneylenders (**dikus**) and Company officials.

Answer: (B)

Q8. Following the suppression of the 1855–56 rebellion, the British carved out a separate administrative district known as:

(A) Damin-i-Koh
(B) Bhagalpur Hills
(C) Santhal Pargana
(D) Ranchi Division

Sol. Q8. The British created the special district of **Santhal Pargana** (5,500 square miles) in 1855, enacting special tenancy laws to protect Santhals from non-tribal exploitation.

Answer: (C)

Q9. The economic rent theory of which classical European economist heavily influenced the formulation of the Ryotwari system in western India?

(A) Adam Smith
(B) Thomas Malthus
(C) David Ricardo
(D) John Stuart Mill

Sol. Q9. The Ryotwari system in Bombay and Madras was inspired by **David Ricardo's** theory of economic rent, which argued that the state should directly claim surplus economic rent from the actual cultivator without landlord intermediaries.

Answer: (C)

Q10. What external international event triggered the unprecedented "Cotton Boom" in the Bombay Deccan between 1861 and 1865?

(A) The Crimean War
(B) The American Civil War
(C) The Franco-Prussian War
(D) The Opium Wars in China

Sol. Q10. The outbreak of the **American Civil War** in 1861 cut off American raw cotton supplies to Lancashire mills, prompting Britain to import vast supplies of cotton from the Bombay Deccan.

Answer: (B)

Q11. The colonial **Limitation Law of 1859** stated that loan bonds between moneylenders and ryots were legally valid for only:

(A) One year
(B) Two years
(C) Three years
(D) Five years

Sol. Q11. The Limitation Law of 1859 limited the legal validity of loan bonds to **three years**. Moneylenders circumvented this by forcing peasants to sign new bonds every three years, compounding interest into principal.

Answer: (C)

Q12. The Deccan Riots of May 1875 originated in which village of the Poona district?

(A) Koregaon **(B)** Supa
(C) Baramati **(D)** Junnar

Sol. Q12. The Deccan peasant uprising began in the market village of **Supa** in the Poona district in May 1875, where ryots attacked sahukars' shops and burned debt account books.

Answer: (B)

Q13. During the Deccan Riots of 1875, what was the primary target of peasant crowds attacking the homes and shops of moneylenders?

(A) Gold and silver ornaments **(B)** Stored grain reserves only
(C) Debt bonds and account books (bahikhatas) **(D)** British government armories

Sol. Q13. The primary objective of the rioters was the destruction of legal debt instruments—promissory notes, debt bonds, and account books (**bahikhatas**)—which were burned in public bonfires.

Answer: (C)

Q14. The Deccan Riots Commission Report submitted to the British Parliament in 1878 concluded that peasant bankruptcy was caused by:

(A) Excessive colonial land revenue demand **(B)** The deceitful usury of moneylenders and peasant extravagance
(C) The complete collapse of the cotton crop due to locusts **(D)** Rebellious instigation by the Peshwa family

Sol. Q14. The official Deccan Riots Commission exonerated the colonial revenue administration, laying the entire blame for peasant ruin on usurious sahukars and alleged peasant spending habits.

Answer: (B)

Q15. Which British doctor and surveyor traveled through Bengal, Bihar, and Mysore compiling detailed topographic and commercial reports for the East India Company?

(A) Alexander Greenlaw **(B)** Colin Mackenzie
(C) Francis Buchanan **(D)** Augustus Cleveland

Sol. Q15. Dr. **Francis Buchanan** (Buchanan-Hamilton) was a Company surgeon and surveyor who surveyed Bengal, Bihar, and the Rajmahal hills between 1800 and 1815, evaluating landscapes for colonial economic exploitation.

Answer: (C)

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Wrong-Answer Clinic (CUET Traps & Common Misconceptions)

Common Mistake / Confusion	NTA Examination Trap	Correct Historical Fact & NCERT Clarification
Confusing Jotedars with Zamindars	Assuming Jotedars were absentee urban landlords.	**Jotedars** were rich **resident** peasants living directly in villages. They controlled sharecroppers (**adhiyars**) and frequently subverted absentee zamindars.
Assuming all Zamindaris collapsed in Bengal	Believing the Permanent Settlement completely destroyed the old landed aristocracy.	While many small estates were partitioned, great zamindars (like Burdwan) survived by using **benami** (fictitious) sales, transferring land to women, and deploying armed **lathyals**.
Confusing Paharias and Santhals	Matching Santhals with the hoe and Paharias with the plough.	The **Paharias** practiced shifting cultivation using the **hoe** (**kural**). The **Santhals** practiced settled agriculture using the **plough**.
Misinterpreting the 1859 Limitation Law	Assuming the law reduced interest rates to 3%.	The law made loan bonds legally valid for **three years**. Moneylenders circumvented it by compelling peasants to renew bonds every three years, compounding interest into principal.
Misunderstanding Deccan Riots Commission Findings	Assuming the Commission blamed the colonial government's high land tax.	The Commission deliberately absolved the colonial revenue system of blame, attributing peasant destitution exclusively to greedy moneylenders.

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